

Instructions for class participation

Before each class you should visit the corresponding page for that class in the "Plan for each class period" section on Canvas.

For most classes, I will be giving a short lecture followed by a class discussion of a paper. You should read the paper prior to class while reviewing the instructor's questions. You do not need to turn in your answers to these questions, they are there to help with comprehension and guide discussion in class.

Class discussions will start off in small groups of ~5-6, with one discussion leader. Discussion will start off by focusing on comprehension of the paper, making sure the setup, methods, and main results of the study are clear to all group members. While the discussion leader will be expecting to facilitate discussion, all students in the group should be actively participating. The instructor and TA will be going around from table to table during discussions to listen in, provide input, answer any questions that come up, etc.

After going over comprehension of the paper, discussion leaders will present the questions they generated to the group. If there is time, we will have discussion leaders switch groups so that students can get multiple perspectives on the paper.

To close, we will discuss the paper together as a class and list off the strengths and weaknesses of the paper, as well as any overall thoughts.

Instructions for leading discussions

You will need to be a leader for in-class discussions 4 times throughout the semester. Please sign up to lead discussions [here](#) [Links to an external site.](#). There should be 7-8 leaders for each discussion. Some classes will not have any discussion leaders.

As a discussion leader, you should read the paper in detail, potentially multiple times depending on how confident you are after the first read. While reading the paper, answer all of the instructor's questions. If you are not sure on one of the instructor's questions, do your best and then make note of where you were confused so you can discuss with the group.

After reading the paper in detail and answering the instructor's questions, generate 4-5 discussion questions that you will present to your group in class and upload these questions to Canvas (under the "Leading in class discussion" assignment) PRIOR to class.

These should be open-ended questions that promote critical analysis and discussion of the paper, not just asking about specific details or results from the paper. There are many possible directions to go, the main point is that you are identifying big-picture questions that came up to you while reading the paper. Consider presenting ideas for future studies or follow-ups needed; criticism of the paper and/or things the paper missed; questions about the evolutionary significance of a behavior / why this trait evolved (think about Tinbergen's questions); hypotheticals (i.e., if this was done, then what would we expect / why); relating paper to another paper or lecture material, or even another field.

Stop by office hours or chat after class if you are struggling with identifying questions.

You will be graded on the thoughtfulness/depth of your questions and your facilitation of discussion during class.